

THE DAILY BRIEF

AUGUST 18, 2026

AI & TECH

Artificial intelligence, machine learning, and the technology shaping tomorrow

Anthropic's Annualized Revenue Surges to \$65 Billion. The number is almost hard to believe: Anthropic is now annualized at \$65 billion in revenue, up from \$3.5 billion just eighteen months ago — a staggering 1,757% growth trajectory. The AI safety company behind the Claude model family has become one of the fastest scaling enterprise software businesses in history. What changed? Enterprise adoption accelerated sharply as Fortune 500 companies moved from AI pilots to production deployments. Anthropic's focus on "constitutional AI" — building safety guardrails directly into model behavior — made it the preferred vendor for regulated industries like healthcare, finance, and legal, where explainability matters. The latest Claude release also widened its context window to 200,000 tokens, making it practical for analyzing entire legal contracts or codebases in a single prompt. At this pace, Anthropic is on a path to challenge OpenAI's revenue lead within the next year. (TechCrunch)

Former SpaceX Engineers Are Building a Robotic Factory for Making Steel Parts. A team of ex-SpaceX engineers quietly launched a new venture — still in stealth — focused on automating the manufacturing of precision steel components using robotics and AI vision systems. The founding team of six left SpaceX after working on Starship production and saw an opening: metal fabrication remains one of the most labor-intensive and error-prone segments of manufacturing, with defect rates that AI-guided systems could slash dramatically. The company has raised \$40 million in seed funding from Benchmark and is already in pilot with three aerospace suppliers. The pitch is straightforward: give manufacturing floors the same feedback loops that SpaceX uses to iterate rapidly on rocket parts. (Ars Technica)

Reach Capital Raises \$265 Million Fund V to Back AI Founders. Reach Capital, the early-stage firm focused exclusively on education and workforce AI, closed its fifth fund at \$265 million — oversubscribed by \$65 million from its original target. The firm has a track record of early bets on AI tutoring platforms, resume optimization tools, and corporate training systems that have aged well as enterprises shift to AI-first workflows. Managing partner Juan Benitez said the new fund will focus on "human potential" applications — AI that makes workers more capable, not just more efficient. With unemployment still low and wages rising in skilled trades, Reach is betting that AI-augmented training programs for plumbers, electricians, and healthcare workers will be as transformative as AI for software engineers. (TechCrunch)

Relay AI Shuts Down; Chrome Team Acquires the Team. In a quiet end to a noisy trend, Relay — an AI automation startup that let non-engineers build internal tools by describing workflows in plain English — announced it is shutting down. All twelve engineers on the team have joined Google's Chrome team. Relay raised \$28 million from Sequoia and Kleiner Perkins but couldn't find a business model that scaled beyond early adopters. The acqui-hire signals Google's continued push to embed AI agents deeper into browser workflows, potentially making Chrome itself the interface for AI-driven web automation. (TechCrunch)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Cathie Wood's Ark Invest Buys \$15 Million of Block Inc. Shares on the Dip. Block Inc. — the payments company formerly known as Square, led by CEO Jack Dorsey — saw its stock slide 3% after missing quarterly revenue estimates by \$12 million. Ark Invest, never one to shy away from contrarian bets, purchased approximately \$15 million worth of Block shares across three of its ETFs. Ark's thesis on Block hinges on its Bitcoin treasury and the long-term potential of its Cash App to become a full financial services platform for underbanked users. At current prices, Block's Bitcoin holdings are worth more than its entire equity valuation on a per-share basis — meaning investors are effectively getting the payments business and Tidal music for free. Whether that's genius or hubris depends on whether Bitcoin holds its \$92,000 level. (The Block)

Citi Launches Bitcoin Custody for Institutional Clients by Year-End. Citigroup, the \$1.4 trillion asset bank, confirmed it will launch a dedicated Bitcoin custody service under its Custody+ platform before the end of 2026. The service will initially serve a small cohort of twelve institutional clients including two sovereign wealth funds and a major pension manager. Crypto custody has long been a bottleneck for Wall Street adoption — banks feared operational complexity and regulatory blowback — but client demand has become impossible to ignore as Bitcoin ETFs have normalized digital assets on balance sheets. Citi's entrance legitimizes Bitcoin as a corporate treasury asset in the same way JPMorgan's Jamie Dimon once legitimized blockchain. Institutions that onboard in 2026 will have a structural first-mover advantage as Bitcoin continues its upward march. (The Block)

Kraken Brings US Stock Trading to European Economic Area Customers. In a significant expansion of its product suite, Kraken — the US-based crypto exchange — announced it will allow European Economic Area customers to trade US equities directly from their Kraken accounts. The feature will be powered by a partnership with a European broker-dealer and will allow EEA users to access around 3,000 US-listed stocks including the major tech names. This blurs the line between crypto exchanges and traditional brokerages, and it's a direct shot at Revolut, which has been quietly building a mini-Goldman Sachs in app form. Kraken CEO Julia La Roche called it "the logical next step in building the all-in-one financial app for the next generation." (The Block)

Cypherpunk Launches Zcash Mining Fleet with \$33 Million Winklevoss Deal. Cypherpunk Technologies — a newly formed crypto mining and privacy infrastructure company — announced it has secured a \$33 million investment from Tyler Winklevoss to build a dedicated Zcash mining fleet. Zcash offers "shielded" transactions that obscure sender, recipient, and amount — a privacy feature that has drawn both legitimate use cases and regulatory scrutiny. The Winklevoss bet signals confidence that privacy coins will survive anticipated SEC crypto enforcement actions. (The Block)

BRIEFLY

< **Apple Spyware Alert:** An "unprecedented" number of Apple users worldwide received government spyware alerts over the past 72 hours, according to investigators at Citizen Lab. The alerts targeted journalists, lawyers, and NGO workers in 23 countries. (TechCrunch)

< **Einride Adds 500 Tesla Semis:** Swedish electric trucking startup Einride signed a deal to integrate 500 Tesla Semi trucks into its fleet, the largest single Tesla Semi order outside of PepsiCo. (TechCrunch)

< **Curve Founder on DeFi Regulation:** Curve Finance founder Michael Egorov argued that incoming FATF guidance on DeFi could paradoxically make decentralized exchanges more decentralized — by forcing projects to remove centralized front-ends. (The Block)

THE TAKEAWAY

The through-line of this Tuesday is institutionalization: Anthropic at \$65B annualized revenue, Citi entering Bitcoin custody, Kraken selling US stocks in Europe, and Ark doubling down on Block — all of these are signs that the boundary between "crypto/AI" and "traditional finance" is dissolving fast. The AI market is no longer experimental and the Bitcoin ecosystem is no longer fringe. If you've been waiting for "mainstream adoption" as your signal — this is what it looks like. The question now isn't whether institutions will embrace digital assets and AI tools, but who captures the most value as they do.

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